

Pronoun Guidance and Information

At GitLab, Diversity, Inclusion, & Belonging are written into our values.

Part of creating an inclusive, respectful workplace is paying attention to the language that we use with each other, including how we use and share pronouns. Our inclusive language guidance is one way we put these values into practice.

Sharing pronouns is always a personal choice, and not everyone will choose to do so. In some regions or contexts, people may not feel comfortable or safe sharing this information, and that choice should be respected.

This page provides an overview of pronouns, why they matter, and how to use and display them across common tools at GitLab.

A global perspective

GitLab is an all-remote company with team members across many countries, cultures, and languages. Pronoun norms vary significantly around the world:

- In some languages, such as Turkish, Finnish, Hungarian, and Bengali, third-person pronouns are not gendered at all, so the concept of gendered pronouns may be unfamiliar.
- In some cultures and regions, openly sharing gender identity may carry personal safety considerations.
- Comfort levels with pronoun-sharing practices differ across cultural contexts, and that's okay.

This guidance is written primarily for English-language communication at GitLab. If you work across languages or cultures, approach pronoun conversations with curiosity and respect rather than assumption.

What are pronouns?

A pronoun is a word (or group of words) that can take the place of a noun or noun phrase. We use pronouns all the time in everyday conversation.

For example:

- I didn't know they painted their kitchen pink this weekend.
- Have you ever seen a double rainbow?
- It was a life-changing experience.
- Someone left their costume on the stage.
- If you see Josephine, please tell her that she did a great job!

Pronouns help us avoid repeating names and nouns over and over, simplifying writing and communication.

Why pronouns matter

Pronouns are more than just a part of speech. For many people, they are:

- A key part of how they express their gender identity.
- An important signal that others see and respect them as they are.
- An important part of how people might experience respect and inclusion at work.
- A form of allyship through normalizing the practice of sharing pronouns.

Using the pronouns someone shares with you is a straightforward way to show respect. Misusing or disregarding someone's pronouns can feel uncomfortable or disrespectful, even when unintentional.

GitLab is committed to recognizing and using the pronouns that team members identify for themselves. This aligns with our values and our commitment to creating a workplace where everyone belongs and can do their best work.

Types of pronouns

Due to the nature of language, there are many pronouns that one could choose from. Perhaps the most common of these are she/her, they/them, and he/him.

The way people display pronouns vary, but most people choose to display their personal pronouns in the format shown above. Occasionally, one might also include the corresponding possessive pronoun, such as they/them/theirs, as a matter of personal preference or to provide additional clarity.

While these three sets of pronouns are the most common, they are not the only pronouns in use. Some people use neopronouns or other combinations that more accurately reflect how they wish to be referred to.

Singular they

You might have heard that "they" can only be used as a plural pronoun, but singular they has been part of English for centuries. It is widely accepted in modern usage and is an important way for many people to express their gender identity.

Historically, singular "they" has been used when the gender of a person is unknown or unspecified:

- Somebody left their umbrella in the office.
- Could you please let them know where they can pick it up?

Today, many people also use they/them as their pronouns, regardless of whether their gender is known. In that case, you simply use they in the same way you would in the examples above, but now referring to a specific person:

- Alex said they will join the meeting later.
- I met with Jordan and followed up on their questions.

If you're unsure whether singular "they" is acceptable, it is helpful to know that many guides, dictionaries, and organizations recognize and support it.

Multiple pronouns

Some people list more than one set of pronouns, such as:

- she/her or they/them
- he/they
- they/she

In many cases, this means:

- The person is comfortable with any of the sets listed.
- The order usually reflects preference. For example, someone who lists "she/they" may generally prefer "she" but is also comfortable with "they."

If you're unsure what to use, you can:

- Default to the first set listed.
- Ask politely: "I see you use she/her, he/him, or they/them. Do you have a preference for which I use?"
- Use the person's name or neutral language until clarified.

Neopronouns

Some people do not identify with pronouns like she/her, he/him, or they/them. They may use Neopronouns, which are pronouns beyond the most commonly used sets in English.

Examples of neopronouns include (but are not limited to):

- ze / hir / hers
- xe / xem / xyr

Because there are many neopronouns in use, it's not possible to list them all here. The important thing is to:

- Use the pronouns a person shares with you, even if they're new to you.
- Use the same spelling and form the person uses.
- Practice aloud or in writing if you're unfamiliar so it becomes more natural.

For more on neopronouns and related concepts, see the additional resources section below.

When pronouns aren't shared

If someone has not shared their pronouns:

- Use their name when referring to them.
- Use neutral language such as "they" where appropriate.
- Check available profiles (such as Slack, GitLab, or email signatures) if relevant.

Avoid making assumptions about someone's pronouns based on appearance, name, or voice.

General etiquette for pronouns

As with someone's name, you should respect the pronouns that someone shares with you when referring to them. If someone uses he/him pronouns, it would be inappropriate to refer to him using other pronouns, unless specified. Just as it would be disrespectful to intentionally misgender you, you should make the effort to correctly gender other people.

Pronoun etiquette is similar to name etiquette:

- Use the pronouns someone shares with you. Treat them as you would treat their name.
- Don't assume pronouns based on appearance, name, or voice.
- If you're unsure, it's often better to ask respectfully or use neutral language.

Some examples of asking about pronouns in a work-appropriate way:

- "Hi, I'm Taylor, and I use they/them pronouns. How should I refer to you?"
- "I want to make sure I get this right. What pronouns do you use?"

As with any personal information, be mindful of context:

- In large or mixed settings where someone has not volunteered their pronouns, avoid putting them on the spot.

- Follow the person's lead on where and how they share their pronouns (like Slack profile, Zoom display name, or introductions).

Making mistakes

Mistakes happen, and most people will understand that. How you respond when you make a mistake can make a meaningful difference.

If you accidentally use the wrong pronoun for someone:

1. Correct yourself briefly.
- Example: "She—sorry, they mentioned that in the last meeting."
2. Move on without making it a bigger moment than necessary.

Over-apologizing or drawing out the interaction can make the other person feel uncomfortable or spotlighted.

If you realize the mistake later, for example after seeing someone's pronouns in Slack, you can follow up directly:

- "Hi, I realized I used the wrong pronoun for you earlier. I'm sorry about that and will be more mindful going forward."

If you notice that you're frequently using the wrong pronouns for someone:

- Practice using the person's pronouns when you think or talk about them.
- Update any notes, documents, or templates you control so they reflect the correct pronouns.
- Gently model the correct pronouns in group settings (without calling attention to the person).

Setting your pronouns in applications

If you choose to share your pronouns, you can add them in various tools we use at GitLab. This can help others refer to you correctly and model inclusive behavior.

GitLab.com

You can add your GitLab.com pronouns on your GitLab profile.

Your pronouns might be visible in places like your profile and certain UI elements, depending on configuration.

Google Mail (Gmail)

You can add your pronouns in your email signature. This can be especially helpful when communicating externally.

Slack

You can add your Slack pronouns on your Slack profile.

Team members may also choose to include pronouns in their display name or custom fields, depending on workspace settings.

Zoom

You can add your Zoom pronouns through the Zoom web portal.

In Zoom, you can also control when your pronouns are shown (for example, always, or only when you choose to display them).

Additional resources

These external resources offer more context and deeper learning on pronouns, gender identity, and inclusive language.

- Reference: [Pronouns.org](https://pronouns.org)
- Article: [A Guide To Gender Identity Terms](#)
- Article: ['She/They' and Other Pronouns You Might See on Candidate Profiles](#)
- Book: [Gender: A Graphic Guide](#)
- Book: [What's Your Pronoun? Beyond He and She](#)
- Book: [A Quick & Easy Guide to They/Them Pronouns](#)